

GRADE 7 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.7.7

Text vs. Multimedia

Compare and contrast a written article and a documentary description about the Dust Bowl, analyzing how each medium portrays the subject and what techniques are unique to each.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.7.7: Compare and contrast a written article and a documentary description a...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Written articles use data, quotes, and structured explanation to inform. Documentaries use techniques articles cannot: archival footage, survivor interviews, narration, and music. Comparing the two means noticing what each medium can show or tell that the other cannot.

Modeled Example

An article states a fact with a statistic. How might a documentary present the same fact differently?

A documentary might show the statistic as an on-screen graphic while a narrator reads it aloud, or pair it with footage that visually demonstrates its scale, adding a visual and audio dimension text alone cannot.

An article quotes a historical figure's written account. How might a documentary use that same account differently?

A documentary might have an actor or narrator read the account aloud over related archival footage, or use an actual audio recording if one exists, adding emotional tone through voice.

Written Article: Dust and Drought

1. Between 1930 and 1936, the Great Plains received less than 75 percent of normal rainfall across a massive stretch of Oklahoma, Texas, Kansas, Colorado, and New Mexico. Combined with decades of aggressive farming that had stripped away native prairie grasses, the drought created conditions for one of the worst environmental disasters in American history: the Dust Bowl.
2. Without deep-rooted grasses to hold topsoil in place, wind lifted millions of tons of dry earth into the air. The resulting storms, known as "black blizzards," could reduce visibility to near zero and travel hundreds of miles, depositing Great Plains dust as far away as Chicago and New York City.
3. The economic toll compounded the environmental one. Crop failures pushed an estimated 2.5 million people to leave the Plains states during the 1930s, many traveling to California in search of agricultural work, only to find wages driven down by the sheer number of displaced workers competing for the same jobs.
4. In response, the federal government established the Soil Conservation Service in 1935, promoting new farming techniques: contour plowing, crop rotation, and windbreak tree plantings designed to hold soil in place. These methods, combined with a return of more typical rainfall by the early 1940s, gradually stabilized the region.

Voices from the Dust

OPENING: Black-and-white archival footage of a dust storm rolling across flat farmland, filmed from a moving car. No narration for the first fifteen seconds — only the sound of wind, amplified.

NARRATOR (V.O.): "They called it Black Sunday. April 14th, 1935." Footage cuts to a newspaper clipping, camera slowly zooming on the headline.

INTERVIEW: An elderly woman, filmed in her home, describing her memory of that day as a child: "The sky just went black. Middle of the afternoon, and my mother lit a lamp." Her voice shakes slightly on the word "black." The camera holds on her face for a long moment after she finishes speaking.

ARCHIVAL FOOTAGE: A family loading a truck with mattresses, furniture, and cardboard boxes, intercut with a hand-drawn 1930s map showing migration routes from Oklahoma to California, an animated line tracing the route as the narrator speaks.

INTERVIEW: A historian, seated in an archive room surrounded by filing boxes, explaining the wage impact: "You had more workers than jobs, and that math is brutal. Wages collapsed." Cut to a black-and-white photograph of a labor camp, the camera panning slowly across rows of tents.

CLOSING: Present-day color footage of the same Oklahoma farmland, now green, windbreak trees visible in straight rows along the field's edge. Music swells slightly as the shot holds for several seconds

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit statistic does the written article give about rainfall in paragraph 1?
2. How does the documentary's opening handle the same general subject (the dust storms) differently from the article's opening?

Guided Practice

3. What technique does the documentary use to convey the date of "Black Sunday" that the article does not use for any specific date?

4. What does the interview with the elderly woman add to the documentary that the written article, using only third-person description, cannot provide in the same way?

Guided Practice

5. Why might the camera "hold on her face for a long moment" after she finishes speaking?

6. How does the written article convey the scale of migration in paragraph 3, and how does the documentary convey the same information differently?

Partner Discussion

7. What effect does the animated map likely have on a viewer that the number "2.5 million" alone might not?

8. How does the historian's interview in the documentary compare to how the article explains the wage impact in paragraph 3?

Partner Discussion

9. What does the documentary do immediately after the historian's quote about wages, and what effect does this create?

Independent Practice

10. How does the article end, compared to how the documentary ends?

11. What does the documentary's closing shot (present-day green farmland) show that the article's closing paragraph only describes in words?

Independent Practice

12. Identify one technique unique to the written article that the documentary description does not use.

13. Identify one technique unique to the documentary that the written article cannot use.

Independent Practice

14. How do both the article and the documentary address the same core event (the Dust Bowl's causes) using different methods?

15. Why might a historian prefer using the written article to research exact statistics, but prefer the documentary to understand the human impact?

Small-Group Work

16. How does music function in the documentary's closing in a way that has no equivalent in the written article?

17. Compare how each medium portrays "recovery" from the Dust Bowl.

Small-Group Work

18. If you were adapting paragraph 1's rainfall statistic into a documentary scene, what technique would you use and why?

19. Explain one way the documentary might risk oversimplifying the event compared to the article's explanation.

Exit Ticket

20. Write two or three sentences comparing one technique from each medium and its specific effect on the audience.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. The Great Plains received less than 75 percent of normal rainfall between 1930 and 1936.
2. Instead of stating facts and statistics, the documentary opens with archival footage and amplified wind sound, with no narration for the first fifteen seconds, creating an immersive, sensory experience rather than an informational one.
3. A narrator states the date aloud while the camera zooms on an actual newspaper clipping from that day, combining spoken word and a visual historical artifact.
4. A first-person, emotional eyewitness account, including her voice shaking on the word "black," which conveys a personal, felt experience the article's factual paragraph 2 does not attempt to capture.
5. To let the emotional weight of her memory register with the viewer, a technique specific to visual media that a written article cannot replicate in the same way.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. The article uses a specific number: "an estimated 2.5 million people." The documentary instead uses an animated map with a moving line tracing the migration route, visually representing the movement rather than stating a number.
7. It shows the physical distance and direction of the migration, helping viewers visualize the journey geographically, something a number alone does not convey.
8. The article states plainly that wages were "driven down"; the historian's interview uses a more vivid, spoken phrase — "that math is brutal" — adding a stronger emotional and conversational tone to the same basic fact.
9. It cuts to a black-and-white photograph of a labor camp, with the camera panning slowly across rows of tents — pairing the spoken claim with a visual that reinforces the scale of displacement.
10. The article ends with a factual, informational summary of recovery efforts (the Soil Conservation Service and new farming techniques). The documentary ends with present-day footage of the same land, now green, paired with swelling music, creating an emotional sense of resolution.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. It visually demonstrates the land's recovery, letting viewers see the contrast between the historical dust storms and the present-day green fields, rather than just reading that recovery occurred.

12. The written article can state precise statistics and dates directly and efficiently in a single sentence (such as "75 percent of normal rainfall") without needing a visual or spoken equivalent.

13. Amplified ambient sound (like the wind in the opening) or a survivor's trembling voice during an interview — audio techniques only available in a medium with sound.

14. The article explains the causes factually in paragraph 1 (drought combined with aggressive farming); the documentary conveys the same general idea more atmospherically through the opening dust storm footage and the woman's memory of the sky going black.

15. The article provides precise, citable numbers and dates efficiently, while the documentary's interviews and archival footage convey the emotional, lived experience of the event in a way statistics alone cannot.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. The swelling music creates an emotional mood (a sense of hopeful resolution) purely through sound, a technique with no direct equivalent in text, which can only describe a mood in words.

17. The article portrays recovery factually, listing specific techniques (contour plowing, crop rotation, windbreaks) and their result; the documentary portrays recovery visually and emotionally, showing green present-day footage without restating the specific techniques.

18. Answers vary; require a specific technique (an on-screen graphic, narrated statistic over relevant footage, etc.) and an explanation of how it would convey the same information as the written statistic.

19. Answers vary; a reasonable answer might note the documentary spends more time on emotional interviews and less on the specific combination of drought and farming practices that the article explains clearly in paragraph 1.

20. Answers vary; require one clearly identified technique from the article, one from the documentary, and an explanation of each one's specific effect, not just a general statement that they are "different."

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer